

Designing a Fair Economy Project Plan

Living research framework v0.2 | September 26, 2026

Project founder: Steve Smith · Project positions decided by contributor vote

This is the complete working concept and research plan. It explains the intended human outcomes, the reasons behind the proposed direction, the candidate mechanisms, and the work needed to assess them. It remains a work in progress.

Purpose

Explore how society can give people enough economic security to direct their own lives, preserve their freedom to pursue different ambitions and outcomes, and prevent accumulated wealth or institutional authority from becoming lasting control over others—through a transition that people can afford, influence, and survive.

The intended result is an economic and institutional framework capable of continuous peaceful correction while preserving human agency. Its financing, ownership arrangements, service programs, and governance mechanisms remain subjects for investigation. A clear purpose does not establish that any proposed mechanism will achieve it.

Why this project exists

Freedom requires a practical ability to choose

A person can possess formal rights while having little economic room to exercise them. Leaving an unsuitable job, pursuing education, starting a business, caring for family, or changing direction may be legally possible yet financially out of reach.

This project asks what level of security would make those choices realistically available. Food, housing, healthcare, and other essentials matter both as human needs and as conditions that affect people's ability to direct their lives. The content and financing of that security remain open questions.

An economic floor should provide room for agency. Its design must therefore be examined for dependency, intrusive conditions, administrative exclusion, and any new authority it gives institutions over the people they serve.

Different people should remain free to pursue different lives

The framework seeks to preserve entrepreneurship, personal property, ambition, exceptional achievement, and the possibility of substantial success. It also makes room for people who prefer modest living, family time, creative work, community involvement, or other priorities.

People need not contribute equal amounts, work equal hours, or reach equal outcomes. The question is how to protect meaningful choice while allowing those differences. A framework that secures basic needs but dictates how everyone should live would fail its purpose.

Success must remain compatible with other people's freedom

A central concern is the possibility of a reinforcing cycle: wealth creates influence, influence shapes the rules, and favorable rules generate further wealth and influence. The research must examine when economic success becomes durable control over other people's opportunities or over the institutions meant to serve them.

This concern extends to governments, corporations, unions, political movements, professional bodies, and institutions created by reform itself. Moving authority to a different institution does not establish that the authority will be used well.

The objective is to keep power open to challenge, correction, and replacement. Transparency is one tool, but the framework must also consider informal influence, collusion, circumvention, and capture of the oversight mechanisms themselves.

Participation in future prosperity should be broader

Broad ownership is being explored because the distribution of future growth can affect both economic independence and the distribution of power. Employee ownership, diversified investment structures, cooperatives, retirement assets, and other arrangements are candidate mechanisms.

The underlying question is whether more people can participate in productive wealth and its returns, rather than relying exclusively on wages and recurring transfers. Each option must be tested for risk, access, control, and the possibility that it creates another concentration of power. None is presumed sufficient on its own.

How the main ideas connect

Element	Purpose within the framework
Economic security	Give people enough stability to exercise meaningful choice.
Personal freedom and competitive markets	Preserve different ambitions, experimentation, enterprise, and outcomes.
Broader productive ownership	Examine how participation in future growth can support independence and opportunity.
Contestable power and distributed governance	Limit the conversion of success or public authority into lasting domination.
Continuous evaluation and correction	Allow failures to be addressed and future generations to choose better arrangements.
A survivable transition	Protect people and essential capacity while changes are developed and tested.

These elements must be assessed together. A policy can improve one dimension while damaging another—for example, expanding security while imposing excessive control, or increasing ownership while exposing vulnerable households to risks they cannot absorb.

The transition is part of the purpose

An improved destination would not justify a transition that destroys the security or freedom of the people it is intended to help. Existing employment, food production, healthcare, housing, finance, energy, and infrastructure cannot simply be assumed to continue after their supporting arrangements are dismantled.

The working approach is to introduce changes incrementally, reuse existing capacity where possible, test alternatives before retiring essential arrangements, and make intermediate stages useful even if the wider transformation stops. Parallel operation may be necessary, but duplicating entire systems indefinitely would impose costs of its own.

This approach is intended to permit substantial structural change over time. Its pace must reflect real capacity and observed results. Evaluation must also examine whether delay, obstruction, or capture prevents needed improvements.

Who pays and who does the work

The discussion explicitly confronted the cost of building new arrangements. Public funding does not itself create trained workers, housing, energy, materials, or administrative capacity. Each proposal must identify the resources required and what other uses of those resources would be forgone.

People already struggling to afford necessities have little margin with which to finance an uncertain future benefit. Their experience of a successful transition should be greater security before significant new transition burdens are imposed. Protecting basic security does not require preserving every existing economic advantage.

Financing must therefore be examined alongside household effects, labor supply, capacity constraints, and the timing of costs and benefits. Returns from new institutions cannot be assumed to pay their initial construction costs before those returns exist.

People must be able to influence the transition

The project should give people enough evidence to judge proposed changes: what they cost, who pays, who benefits, what fails, and what alternatives exist. Public participation should affect decisions. It should remain possible to reject, revise, or stop an unsuccessful approach.

A system intended to limit concentrated power must examine whether its own creation depends on concentrating enough authority to override the people affected by it.

Education for service as one candidate mechanism

Education-for-service arose from two linked questions: how people could gain access to education, and where some of the skilled labor needed to expand public capacity could come from. Its possible role is reciprocal investment: society helps develop a person's capabilities, and that person contributes a defined period of useful service.

The project owner's proposal is that accepting educational support creates at least a one-year service obligation regardless of graduation, with capability-based service matching for participants with disabilities. The compact is being explored as an optional route to education. These are design inputs; detailed contractual provisions remain unresolved.

The proposed connection to the wider framework is that educational access could develop individual opportunity while service contributes to healthcare, infrastructure, education, technology, research, or other demonstrated public needs. Whether it adds useful capacity at a justifiable cost must be evaluated against alternatives.

Paid service, proportional additional years, vocational eligibility, waivers, and specific governance mechanisms remain proposals requiring explicit decisions. Actual capability, accommodations, changing circumstances, government failure to place participants, and practical exit options require examination. Participation in education does not by itself establish sustained employment capacity.

The design must address exploitation, displacement of regular workers, suppression of wages, and the risk of dividing people into those who can purchase an unrestricted education and those who must accept burdensome service terms. Useful work is a benefit to evaluate; it is not automatically cash revenue available to fund tuition.

Education-for-service is one possible contribution to the transition. The project's purpose and scope extend to security, ownership, markets, governance, and power whether this particular mechanism is ultimately adopted, revised, or rejected.

Purpose, proposals, and evidence

Maintain three distinctions throughout the work:

1. **Purpose and guiding values:** the human outcomes and institutional problems the project exists to address.
2. **Proposed mechanisms:** candidate arrangements whose design and adoption remain open to review.
3. **Empirical and legal claims:** statements requiring evidence, appropriate scope, and explicit limitations.

Uncertainty about a mechanism should prompt investigation or revision. The documentation should continue to explain the purpose that mechanism is intended to serve.

This plan is a working synthesis of the available discussion, revised with the project owner's authorization to restore the rationale. It is not a verbatim transcript or a claim that the complete originating conversation has been recovered.

Scope and intended results

Investigate an economic framework that permits meaningful individual freedom and broad opportunity without requiring equal outcomes or concentrating unlimited authority in the state. Explore how existing capitalist and socialist arrangements might evolve through useful, testable reforms. Do not assume that an ideological label determines whether a mechanism serves the goals.

The research cycle should produce a clear charter, definitions, evidence and claim register, compared policy options, reproducible feasibility model, service-compact design, failure scenarios, and explicit recommendations. A future pilot requires a separate decision, credible funding, qualified review, and protection for affected people.

The repository is the living record of this inquiry. Integrate new ideas into the whole framework, identify their status, and revise connected sections together. Documentation completeness means preserving the purpose and known proposals while clearly identifying gaps; it does not mean pretending the missing parts of the original conversation have been recovered.

Research workstreams and their purpose

Economic security and household resilience

Determine which necessities and economic margins support meaningful choice. Compare cash, services, and combined provision; define eligibility and regional variation. Examine benefit cliffs, take-up, exclusion, administrative burden, and conditions that give providers excessive control. Produce a floor options paper and household scenarios. Begin with R06, R08, and R11, then obtain evidence appropriate to the chosen jurisdiction.

Ownership and competitive markets

Compare employee ownership, diversified citizen investment structures, cooperatives, retirement participation, and profit sharing. Examine voting rights, liquidity, portability, inheritance, investment risk, and concentration of wages and savings in one employer. Address natural monopolies, market entry, and competitive conditions. Evaluate effects on independence and power as well as financial returns. The existing reference set is insufficient; add primary research and evaluations of outcomes.

Governance and resistance to capture

Map who appoints, funds, audits, disciplines, and removes each institution. Test informal influence, revolving doors, procurement favors, collusion among oversight bodies, and capture of public investment structures. Compare distributed authority with its coordination costs. Produce an authority map and risk register tied to the ability of affected people to challenge decisions. Begin with R01-R03 and R19.

Financing and real capacity

Identify initial and recurring costs, the ultimate incidence of funding mechanisms, training bottlenecks, infrastructure needs, and capacity that can be reused. Compare spending reallocation, taxation, limited borrowing, and eventual investment returns. Test the timing of compensation and whether claimed savings actually free usable resources. R04 and R06-R08 provide context whose country and modeling limits must be preserved.

Education and public service

Develop the compact as a possible link between individual opportunity and the capacity required for public improvement. Compare it with ordinary hiring, scholarships without service, apprenticeships, and retention incentives. Evaluate useful additional output, participant agency, accessibility, job displacement, and retention. Begin with R12-R18 and R20; military arrangements provide context and do not automatically establish suitable civilian enforcement.

Transition and public legitimacy

Compare sequences that keep essential systems working and improve vulnerable people's position early. Examine public participation, compensation, reversibility, and the risk of indefinite delay. Document how input changes proposals. Produce an implementation sequence and evaluation plan that disclose who pays, who benefits, and who could lose. Begin with R01, R03-R05, and R09-R11, retaining the unresolved R05 citation limitation.

Education for service design questions

- Acceptance and accrual: distinguish signing, enrollment, and funding disbursement. Examine a cooling-off period, reversed or small payments, a fixed minimum, funded-year accrual, and a maximum obligation.
- Eligibility and benefit: consider admissions, residency, prior education, program quality, tuition caps, living support, part-time study, and vocational pathways. Test price inflation and low-value enrollment.
- Compensation and conditions: examine salary, benefits, wage parity, hours, caregiving, relocation, part-time equivalence, and representation. Paid service remains a recommendation pending contributor adoption of its terms.
- Placement: define useful public benefit, approved employers, participant choice, local and remote work, supervision, and maximum waiting time. Specify relief when government cannot provide suitable

work.

- Disability and hardship: match duties to actual capability; examine accommodations, episodic conditions, changed circumstances, caring duties, postponement, and appeals. Resolve genuine inability without presuming that study proves sustained employment capacity.
- Withdrawal and breach: compare transfer, proportionate repayment, hardship relief, and government breach. Assess whether a nominally voluntary contract preserves practical exit options. Obtain qualified legal review before relying on enforceability.
- Equity and additional value: measure burden by income, disability, geography, age, and family status. Account for participants who would have served anyway, displaced regular jobs, and supervision costs.

Produce a plain-language specimen agreement only after the major options are clear. Mark unresolved clauses and preserve the one-year minimum as an owner proposal, without inventing additional adopted obligations.

Feasibility and evaluation

Keep three accounts distinct: public cash costs and receipts; real workers, materials, facilities, and time; and costs and benefits experienced by different households. A budget saving is not necessarily an increase in total useful capacity.

For each cohort and year estimate education funding, salary and benefits, administration, accommodation, supervision, facilities, and financing costs. Subtract only justified budget savings or receipts. Report gross and net costs. Public service output is not automatically spendable revenue.

Vary enrollment, completion, placement delays, wage growth, service length, supervisory load, withdrawal, and retention. State discount rates and inflation assumptions. Report ranges, opportunity costs, and sensitivity to uncertain inputs rather than a single confident projection.

Measure the purposes directly:

- Economic security: resources after essential costs, hardship, arrears, access delays, and benefit cliffs.
- Practical freedom: genuine ability to change jobs or direction, unwanted placements, exit burdens, intrusive conditions, and complaint outcomes.
- Opportunity and ownership: participation, access, concentration, investment risk, and control over productive assets.
- Public capacity: additional useful service relative to a credible baseline, adjusted for displacement and supervision.
- Fiscal performance: gross and net spending, cost per additional service unit, liabilities, and overruns.
- Institutional power: concentration of authority, conflicts, meaningful routes to challenge decisions, audit effectiveness, and reversibility.

Set thresholds before a pilot with affected participants and appropriate reviewers. Use credible comparison groups where feasible and disclose selection bias, spillovers, and uncertainty. Small-scale success does not establish national or international scalability. R01 and R09-R10 inform evaluation and participation; no numerical success thresholds are adopted here.

Roadmap and review checkpoints

Phase 0 Foundation

Prepare the charter, glossary, proposal status, decision log, and reference inventory. Connect every workstream to a human outcome. The checkpoint confirms scope and identifies missing context; it does not require reauthorizing routine documentation updates.

Phase 1 Evidence

Appraise R01-R20, recover blocked sources, correct mismatched support, and add program comparisons and counterevidence. Each material claim must have appropriate support or an explicit unresolved flag.

Phase 2 Design options

Compare at least two plausible alternatives and the existing-system baseline for each major choice in security, ownership, finance, governance, and service. Explain trade-offs across the complete goals before selecting an option.

Phase 3 Feasibility

Model budgets, household effects, workforce capacity, dependencies, and implementation limits. Funding and resource assumptions must be explicit and sensitivity tests reproducible. No assumed free labor or guaranteed investment return.

Phase 4 Challenge

Test adverse scenarios and seek independent review where available. Resolve critical failures or narrow the proposal. Preserve dissent. Failure can reopen any earlier phase rather than forcing approval to meet a schedule.

Phase 5 Synthesis

Produce the revised framework, integrated source appendix, updated overview, and recommendations. Separate what is established from what remains proposed or unknown. Verify that the document still explains the full purpose.

Phase 6 Conditional pilot design

If warranted, select a limited intervention with evaluation, participant protections, funding, continuity arrangements, and shutdown criteria. Research documentation authorization does not authorize enrollment or spending.

Planning allowance for phases 0-5: approximately 60-100 working hours, excluding specialist review and live-pilot design. At 4-6 hours per week this would imply roughly 10-25 weeks, plus review delays. These are inherited rough estimates, not commitments or a transition timeline for society.

Failure scenarios

- Recession or funding loss: can existing commitments continue, and can a program close without transferring the harm to participants?
- Government placement failure: can an obligation become indefinite, and what accessible alternatives, limits, or relief apply?

- Noncompletion or changed capacity: is the remaining burden proportionate and feasible, with appropriate appeal and hardship treatment?
- Worker displacement or wage suppression: does useful capacity still increase after those effects are counted?
- Provider price inflation: does education support expand access or merely increase prices? Test quality controls and provider incentives.
- Capture of oversight or ownership funds: can people detect, challenge, and reverse control by entrenched interests?
- Supply shortages and scale: do expanding demand, scarce labor, or infrastructure limits erase benefits?
- Security with excessive control: does a floor or service program give institutions intrusive authority over recipients?
- Wealth reconcentration: do new ownership arrangements reproduce the power cycle the framework seeks to address?
- Indefinite transition: do temporary institutions become permanent interests, or does caution prevent correction of known harm?

For each scenario record affected people, mechanism of harm, leading indicators, mitigations, residual risk, and a proposed pause or stop condition. Evaluate the effect of stopping as carefully as the effect of continuing.

Governance of this research project

Contributors adopt and revise project positions by vote. Steve is the founder and initial coordinator, with the same voting rights as other contributors and no unilateral veto. All goals, principles, mechanisms, and governance rules remain revisable. Research support collects evidence, compares alternatives, preserves assumptions, and maintains versions. Independent reviewers may cover economics, finance, labor, disability access, public administration, and law; their participation is not assumed.

Maintain a decision log, claim register, and risk register. Decisions should include ID, date, scope, rationale, evidence, affected documents, and review trigger. Claims require the exact assertion, source passage, date, jurisdiction, counterevidence, and limitations. The current decision record is docs/DECISIONS.md.

At meaningful discussion checkpoints, integrate substantive developments into the repository. Ask a focused question if inclusion, interpretation, or adoption is unclear. Do not silently promote tentative suggestions into agreed policy. Preserve earlier versions in Git history and keep current documents aligned. This process operates during accessible work sessions, not as background monitoring of every conversation.

Contributor review and integration

Open the inquiry to outside reviewers through CONTRIBUTING.md and GOVERNANCE.md. Contributors can challenge claims, offer evidence or lived experience with clear scope, and propose changes without coding or formal credentials. Review must assess the complete purpose, evidence, feasibility, distribution, freedom and power, and alternatives.

The process is a versioned proposal, substantive review, revision, a contributor ballot on a frozen text, a recorded result, and faithful integration through a reviewed pull request. People qualify through traceable project work, including proposals, reviews, explained evidence, relevant lived experience, analysis, and editing. A contribution need not be accepted or agree with the current position. The founder has no unilateral veto; each contributor has one vote.

Adopted decisions guide the current project until revised or reversed by a later valid vote. Everything is revisable, including the purpose, principles, mechanisms, voter criteria, and governance itself. Contributors can propose a reasoned change of judgment without needing new empirical evidence. A vote selects the project's position and does not establish empirical truth.

GOVERNANCE.md defines provisional operating mechanics: contributions precede the announced vote opening; review and voting each last seven days; at least three eligible contributors participate and a non-author provides substantive review; support must exceed half of non-abstaining ballots. A tie, missing participation, or no expressed preference leaves the current position in place. These mechanics are implementation defaults open to contributor revision, not separately founder-approved preferences. There is no low-turnout founder override.

Retain qualification links, ballot versions, timestamps, interests, exclusions, dissent, final text checks, and the merge commit. Maintainers implement valid results rather than exercising a second policy veto. Objective publication or procedural obstacles must be recorded and resolved openly. New substantive text after a vote needs renewed review. Routine faithful synchronization remains authorized. A general project license and stronger technical enforcement remain unresolved.

The September 26 shift from advisory voting to contributor decisions is recorded as an explicit founding clarification, not as a community ballot that did not occur. No ballot automation or branch protection has been installed. Review the procedure after three completed proposals or 30 days of active participation, whichever occurs first; contributors may propose revisions sooner.

Immediate research sequence

1. Use this complete purpose as the basis for glossary and charter decisions; identify any remaining gaps in the available originating discussion.
2. Resolve R05 support and recover R13, R15, R17, and R18. Obtain an official source for the uncited ROTC comparison before using its terms.
3. Compare floor, ownership, and governance options alongside service-compact alternatives. Do not allow the newest mechanism to displace the larger inquiry.
4. Build the first household and cohort models. Prioritize acceptance trigger, compensation, exit, placement failure, and government obligations for the compact.
5. Update the complete proposal, decisions, references, generated editions, and revision history at the next meaningful checkpoint.

Evidence and publication limits

The 20 source links are retained in REFERENCES.md and the generated editions. The originating conversation was truncated; completeness for unseen messages is not claimed. Retrieval does not establish full appraisal or validate the combined framework. The proposal remains a work in progress, and research or publication does not authorize policy implementation.

Reference register

Living reference register for the current project plan. Source IDs and the 20 original links are retained from the September 24, 2026 plan. Retrieval statuses reflect the September 25, 2026 UTC check; the September 26 documentation revision did not reverify these sources. The original discussion was partially truncated, so completeness for unseen messages is not claimed. These sources inform specific research questions and do not validate the combined framework.

Use this register with the full project plan, which explains the purposes the research serves. Add new evidence here with scope, retrieval date, and limitations, then regenerate the PDF and text editions. Preserve conflicting evidence and unresolved citation problems.

R01 OECD Regulatory Policy Outlook 2025 - Regulating for effectiveness

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Evaluation and correction of regulation; phase 1 evidence review.

R02 Opportunities for All - Build efficient and responsive governments

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Capture and responsive government; governance workstream.

R03 Exploring New Frontiers in Citizen Participation - Building Resilient Democracies

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Citizen participation and democratic resilience; consultation design.

R04 The Sequencing and Speed of Reforms in Transition Economies: Implications for the Case of Uzbekistan

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Sequencing and speed; country-specific transition evidence, not proof of a universal path.

R05 Structures, Processes and Governance in Tax Policy-Making - Carlo Cottarelli

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; claim support needs correction. Previously cited for compensation before disruption. Retrieved page concerns tax policymaking; that specific claim remains unsupported by this citation pending passage review.

R06 Government at a Glance 2025 - Poverty and inequality

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Baseline inequality and redistribution measures; distinguish association from causal attribution.

R07 Closing the Gap: A LIC's Policy Options Under an Aid Shock

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Fiscal stress scenarios. Model of an aid-dependent economy; do not generalize its results to every country.

R08 Financing gap for universal social protection: Global, regional and national estimates and strategies for creating fiscal space

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Costing social protection and international variation. Page confirms 3.3% and 52.3% GDP estimates; these are contextual estimates, not this project's budget.

R09 Support for Economic Reforms Hinges on Communication, Engagement, and Trust

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Engagement and reform support; investigate study design and limits before extrapolation.

R10 Getting the Public on Side

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Public acceptance and reform design; compare proposed mechanisms.

R11 Social protection floor

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Definition of a social protection floor; inputs to floor specification.

R12 NHSC Scholarship Program Overview

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Education-for-service precedent in selected health professions; not evidence that a universal scheme would succeed.

R13 US Naval Academy - Admissions Apply

[Original source](#)

Access blocked; not reverified. Military education precedent cited earlier; blocked with HTTP 403, details not reverified.

R14 How to Comply with Scholarship Program Requirements

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Detailed scholarship obligations; assess scope and current contract conditions separately.

R15 US Naval Academy - Blue and Gold Book Admissions

[Original source](#)

Access blocked; not reverified. Noncompletion and service agreements cited earlier; blocked with HTTP 403, details not reverified.

R16 Disability Discrimination and Employment Decisions

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Accessible employment analysis; does not establish that every student can perform every job.

R17 Department of Labor ODEP - Apprenticeship

[Original source](#)

Access blocked; not reverified. Accessible apprenticeship context; blocked with HTTP 403, content not reverified.

R18 Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities - Article 27 Work and employment

[Original source](#)

Access blocked; not reverified. Work and disability rights context; blocked with HTTP 403, content not reverified.

R19 Anti-Corruption and Integrity Outlook 2026

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Integrity implementation and institutional capture; governance evidence review.

R20 The ADA: Your Employment Rights as an Individual With a Disability

[Original source](#)

Retrieved; detailed evidence appraisal pending. Reasonable accommodation and essential job functions; legal applicability needs qualified review.

Evidence gaps

R05 does not yet support the compensation-before-disruption claim. R13, R15, R17, and R18 were blocked in the recorded review. Army ROTC needs an official source before its contractual terms are used. Novelty, repayment value, political support, and expanded-ownership effects require additional research.